

The Noble Sūtra of the Great Complete Nirvāṇa

Ārya Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra · Toh 121 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་ཡངས་སུ་བྱེད་ལས་འདས་པ་ཆེ་པའི་མདོ།

The Noble Sūtra of the Great Passing Beyond Sorrow, known in Sanskrit as the Ārya Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra and in Tibetan as 'Phags pa yongs su mya ngan las 'das pa chen po'i mdo, is a major Mahāyāna sūtra centered on the final days and passing into nirvāṇa of Śākyamuni Buddha, set dramatically in the grove of paired śāla trees near Kuśinagara as the Buddha addresses his disciple Ānanda. The text unfolds as a sweeping prophecy of the ages following the Buddha's parinirvāṇa, describing the successive conditions of the Dharma and its practitioners across the centuries to come. It belongs to the sūtra literature of the Mahāyāna, a genre concerned with the Buddha's final teachings and the enduring nature of buddhahood, and shares broad thematic territory with other recensions of the Mahāparinirvāṇa tradition while carrying its own distinctive emphases. This text is Toh 121 in the Kangyur, catalogued among the Mahāyāna sūtras of that great collection of translated Buddhist scriptures.

Thus settled and established. In the language of India: Ārya Mahāparinirvāṇa Sūtra. In the Tibetan language: The Noble Sūtra of the Great Passing Beyond Sorrow.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling together with a great Saṅgha of one thousand two hundred and fifty monks in the grove of paired śāla trees near the great city of Kuśinagara. At that time, as the final age drew near, the Blessed One declared to the venerable Ānanda:

Ānanda, in the first century after my passing into nirvāṇa, the teaching will hold the Dharma as supreme. My śrāvakas too will delight in the garden of Dharma's joy, and will come to possess a nature endowed with skill in knowledge and with noble wisdom.

Ānanda, at that time there will arise a king named Aśoka who will rule as lord over Jambudvīpa. He will build great stūpas containing the bone-relics of my body after my parinirvāṇa.

Ānanda, in the second century after my passing into nirvāṇa, the teaching will have liberation as its heart. My śrāvakas too will regard me as their Teacher and will become skilled in teaching.

Ānanda, in the third century after my passing into nirvāṇa, the teaching will have practice as its heart. My śrāvakas too will directly realize with their bodies liberation through both aspects, attaining the vision that is direct experience, and will achieve liberation through wisdom.

Ānanda, in the fourth century after my passing into nirvāṇa, the teaching will have solitary retreat as its heart. My śrāvakas too will delight in settling inwardly in stillness.

Ānanda, in the fifth century after my passing into nirvāṇa, the teaching will hold the Dharma as supreme. My śrāvakas too will take delight in the garden of Dharma's joy.

Ānanda, in the sixth century after my passing into nirvāṇa, the teaching will delight in reading and recitation. My śrāvakas too will apply themselves with diligence.

Ānanda, in the seventh century after my passing into nirvāṇa, the teaching will have veneration as its heart. Gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas (dri za, the scent-eaters), asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras (mi'am ci, the part-human celestials), great serpents (mahoragas), humans and non-humans will pay homage and reverence to the teaching, will hold it supreme, will honor it, and will make offerings to it. My śrāvakas too will pursue material gain, respect, and verse.

Ānanda, in the eighth century after my passing into nirvāṇa, there will be quarreling in the teaching. My śrāvakas too will harm one another, will be skilled in holding views that are fixed merely on the letter, will be disrespectful toward their preceptors and teachers, will abide without vigilance, will be deceitful and speak the words of evil persons about themselves, will dwell in the wealth of the Saṅgha and of stūpas as though it were household property, and will associate with the royal court, thereby bringing about ruin.

Ānanda, in the ninth century after my passing into nirvāṇa, the teaching will be stripped of its heart. My śrāvakas too will apply themselves eagerly to the work of household affairs, will delight in agricultural activities at every boundary, will take keen pleasure in buying and selling, will indulge in desire and make their living by sending out servants, will become lazy,

will not guard the trainings (śikṣā) well established by the Tathāgata. Ānanda, in the one-thousandth year after my passing into nirvāṇa, the teaching will be made into mere words without heart. My śrāvakas too will delight in many kinds of worldly talk, and they will abandon this speech of a buddha who has

transcended the world — namely, the collection of discourses (sūtras), the collection of mixed prose and verse, the collection of prophecies, the collection of verse, the collection of intentional utterances, the collection of narrative occasions, the collection of accounts of realization, the collection of legendary tales, the collection of birth stories, the collection of extensive teachings, the collection of marvels, and the collection teaching the analysis of phenomena — and they will instead remain devoted to other pursuits. Specifically, they will become thoroughly attached to talk of kings, talk of thieves, talk of cooking fires, talk of food, talk of drink, talk of friends, talk of oneself, talk of distinctions, talk of young men, talk of young women, talk of cities, and talk of the ocean — and to all such talk as this. Both ascetics (śramaṇas) and brahmins will abandon my holy Dharma. They will be indifferent to this Dharma and Vinaya. As for the monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen: they too will be without cultivation of the body, without cultivation of moral discipline, without cultivation of wisdom, and they will engage in quarreling, in finding fault, and in striving to speak contentiously. They will possess fine alms-bowls and fine robes, yet for the sake of protecting these for a hundred years they will swiftly discard moral discipline. In exactly this way, through mingling with wickedness and being intent upon wickedness, through evil and mental discomfort and the like, the roots of virtue accumulated over a hundred years will likewise be swiftly destroyed.

Ānanda, in the eleven-hundredth year after my passing into nirvāṇa, monks of broken moral discipline will arise and will have many attendants and servants, while those who possess moral discipline will have few attendants and servants.

At that point, the venerable Ānanda, afflicted and distressed, addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, what is the heart of this Dharma and Vinaya?"

The Blessed One declared: "Ānanda, the four applications of mindfulness, the four perfect abandonments, the four bases of miraculous power, the five faculties, the five powers, the seven limbs of awakening, the noble eightfold path, calm abiding, special insight, and the three gateways to liberation — Ānanda, these are the heart of this Dharma and Vinaya.

Ānanda, monks of broken moral discipline will rebuke and find fault with monks who possess moral discipline. When all of them are parted from the body, after death they will fall into an evil destiny, an evil realm, and will

suffer. But all those who, at that time, are without anger will be born in the good destinies."

Having spoken these words, the Blessed One fell silent, and the venerable Ānanda, those monks, that assembly endowed with everything, together with the world of gods, humans, asuras, garuḍas, and gandharvas rejoiced and praised aloud what the Blessed One had taught.

The noble sūtra of the great complete nirvāṇa is concluded.

Translated by the Indian paṇḍita Kamalagupta and the great editor-translator, the monk Rin chen bzang po.

Translator's Notes

- The phrase rendered "liberation through both aspects" translates a technical term referring to liberation through meditative attainment (samādhi) and through wisdom (prajñā), a standard Abhidharma distinction between one liberated in both ways.

The king named Aśoka corresponds to Aśoka (Tibetan mya ngan med, meaning "without sorrow"), the historical Mauryan emperor famous for his stūpa constructions; this is a standard Mahāyāna identification.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the source as provided; the translation reflects this and ends accordingly.

- The twelve-fold classification of canonical scripture listed here follows the standard Tibetan rendering of the twelve aṅgas of Buddhist literature. The translations given follow the most widely accepted scholarly equivalents: mixed prose and verse (geya), prophecies (vyākaraṇa), intentional utterances (udāna), narrative occasions (nidāna), accounts of realization (avadāna), legendary tales (itivṛttaka), birth stories (jātaka), extensive teachings (vaipulya), marvels (adbhuta-dharma), and analysis of phenomena (upadeśa). The precise identification of a few of these with their Sanskrit counterparts admits some variation across traditions, but the overall scheme is unambiguous.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly

proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.
May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.